



**Road ahead:** Croatia faces England on June 17 before taking on Panama on June 24 and Ghana on June 27.

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matches in challenging conditions. How England handles a potential clash against co-host Mexico at Estadio Azteca, situated 7,200 feet above sea level, and a face-off against Brazil in Miami's July heat and humidity will provide a true test of its title credentials.

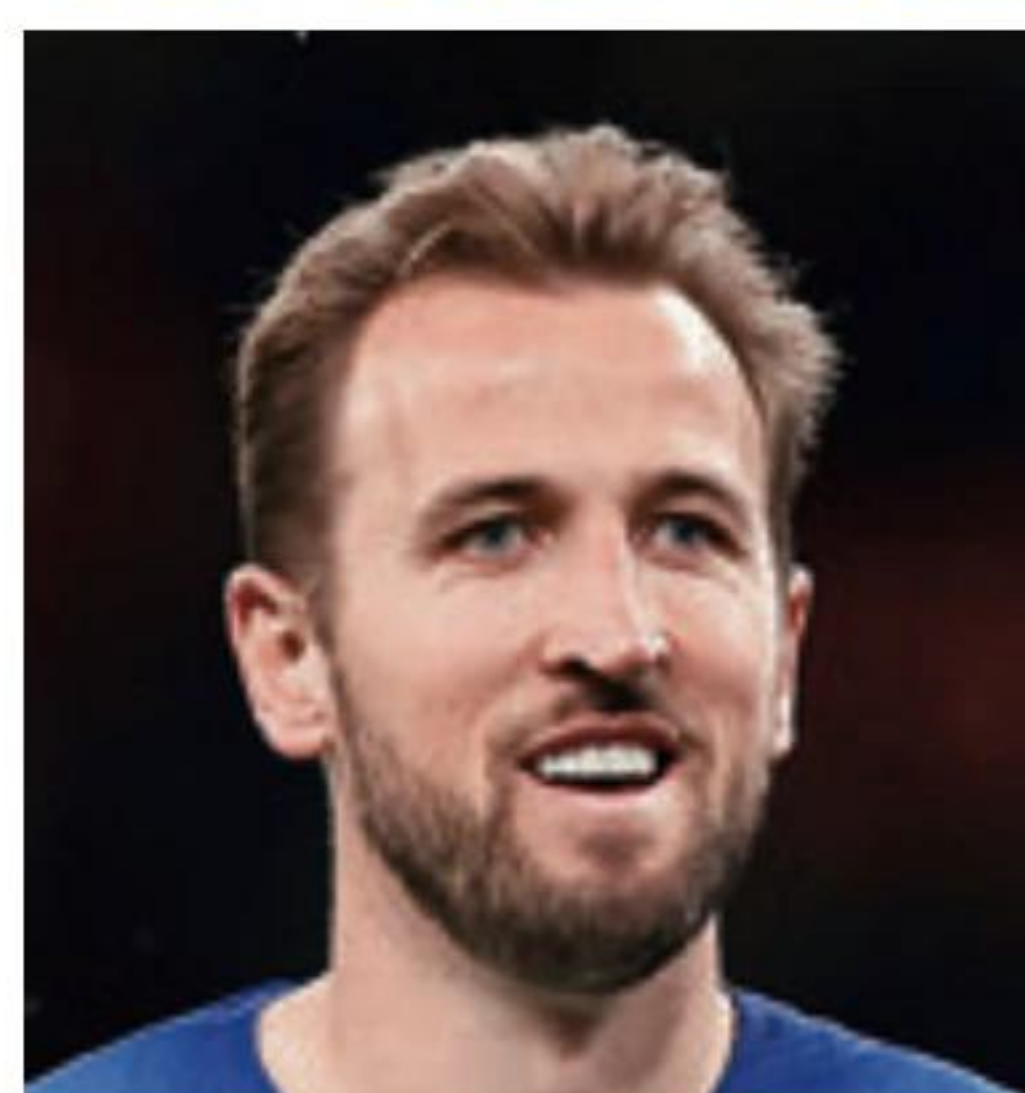
Whether England advances could depend on whether it overcomes Croatia in its opener. Croatia has the talent and experience to overwhelm England. Despite its underdog status, Croatia was the beaten finalist in 2018, upsetting the Three Lions along the way, before finishing third in Qatar four years later. Those recent performances have raised expectations back home for the Vatreni, whose tactical discipline has consistently troubled fancied sides in the latter stages of tournaments.

Zlatko Dalić, who will lead Croatia into his third World Cup, has retained the core of the 2022 setup. Dominik Livaković, Joško Gvardiol, Luka Modrić, Mateo Kovačić, Mario Pašalić, Ivan Perišić and Andrej Kramarić form a formidable spine that tallies a combined 665 international caps between them.

While the squad has a high average age of 28.3, Dalić will hope emerging talents Marco Pašalić, Martin Baturina and Petar Sučić can step up and provide support.

Dalić will also hope star midfielder Modrić,

## ON THE RADAR



### **Harry Kane** (England)

England's all-time leading scorer already has a World Cup Golden Boot from 2018 but will want to banish the ghosts of his penalty miss in the quarterfinal defeat in 2022. His elite finishing, ability to drop deep and pick out runners with his passing make him a dual threat for opposition defences.



### **Luka Modrić** (Croatia)

Even at 40, Modrić, who will feature in his fifth World Cup, remains the heartbeat of this Croatian side. The AC Milan playmaker will dictate Croatia's tempo from midfield. He was named the best player at the 2018 World Cup before winning the Ballon d'Or later that year.